

Kindle Development Kit

Amazon has recently launched the Kindle Development Kit to support apps for the Kindle

Colour eink?

Hanvon introduced a colour eink ebook reader at CES this year

Going beyond paper

For years, people have been reading on PC screens, on phones and, recently, on tablets. However, the best way to read books has always been paper... Does that still hold true?

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Ebook readers have actually been around for a long time. In fact, we can date the origin of ebook readers to SoftBook – a 1.3-kilo, touch-sensitive LCD device that was available in 1998. It boasted of a telephone jack and a 33.6 Kbps internal modem that Americans could use to download newspapers such as the New York Times. Users could get an issue of the daily newspaper – but they had to leave it downloading overnight! Priced at around \$600, the SoftBook was not something regular people could afford, and it wasn't targeted at us common folk anyway.

Although times have changed, our underlying instincts haven't. We continue to innovate and work towards better, slimmer, sleeker products. We're a form-factor conscious generation. Having drooled over this category for long ourselves, we decided to give it a try.

We invited all the significant brands manufacturing ebook readers to participate in a comparison. Having procured the Kindle ourselves, we were left with the other Indian models. Some hesitated and eventually backed out.

We tested a total of five ebook readers – the Touch, Touch Pro and Mega Touch from newcomers Leaf, Pi from Infibeam, and of course, Amazon's Kindle.

If you followed our Web awards a couple of months ago, Infibeam would strike a chord. It's an Indian shopping portal founded by ex-Amazon employees, offering its own brand of

ebook readers and tablets – their Phi tablet was tested by Digit in our January 2011 issue. At the time of going to print, we learned that Infibeam has already announced its latest ebook reader – Pi2 – a touch-enabled device. However, since our test process requires us to spend at least a month with the ebook reader, you'll have to wait for our review of the Pi2 and other new ebook reader launches.

Leaf is the latest entrant in the Indian ebook market. We received three models – Touch, TouchPro and MegaTouch – all three of them touch-enabled. We learned from Leaf that they would be developing all their ebook readers as touch-enabled to cater to a niche audience.

Infibeam Pi

At just 180 grams, the Pi is certainly light in your palms, and we loved it for this. You can use it for hours without any signs of strain in your wrists. We used the Pi while relaxing indoors, standing outdoors and even in public transport. The Pi implements the Vizplex display from E Ink Corporation.

Instead of the standard (and popular) 3.5-mm jack for listening to music, the designers opted for a 3-mm jack. We just couldn't find a decent set of headphones to test it with – very annoying. You can neither use your normal audio headphones nor any other 2.5-mm pair. You're limited to using Infibeam's pair of earphones included in the package.

Besides, there is no distinction between

the various buttons. All you find are four buttons by the left side of the slim body and a large four-way navigation button on the front. There is significant lag in the response of the Pi – something they will hopefully rectify in the Pi2. Infibeam hasn't specified any details on the clock speed of the processor it runs on, but by what we understand, it runs on Samsung's S3C2440 CPU running at a clock speed of 400 MHz. The newer Infibeam Pi2, on the other hand, implements a Freescale Arm 11 Core iMX35 CPU clocked at 533 MHz. This should hopefully translate to increased performance, and smoother page refreshes.

Other than PRC and LIT, the Infibeam supported all the other formats in the list we tested. This is something that impressed us. In contrast, what let us down was the limited internal storage space available – a miserly 512 MB. You have no other option, but to spend extra on a memory card for extra space.

In the absence of either touch or a QWERTY keyboard, jotting down

quick notes or performing a search or navigating through pages can be quite painful for your right thumb!

Given the options available in the market, the price tag of ₹9,999 seems a little high and was disappointing. What goes against the Pi most, however, is its rather flimsy build quality, but then it's also the lightest reader in the test.

Leaf Touch

The Touch model is a basic ebook reader with touch capabilities. It has a display resolution of 600x800 pixels and displays up to 8 levels of gray. It runs an Ingenic Arm 9 processor. The 400 MHz clock speed translates into lags and glitches,



Infibeam Pi: featherweight